MOHAN VS NAVEEN



- The BJP is aiming to position Mohan Majhi's humble origins against Naveen Patnaik, who is still perceived as Odisha's most popular leader
- The governance pattern has shifted from 'top-down' to consensual; decisions are now made by a core ministerial group, not a caucus of babus
- Team Majhi has eliminated Naveen's superbureaucracy
- Majhi is more accessible and reaches out to citizens directly

Five months after taking power in Odisha, in a turn of events whose success may have surprised even the protagonist, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has one objective. To set a governance benchmark by which to distinguish itself from its predecessor. What it grapples with is this: a humble roots politician like Mohan Charan Majhi, elevated to the chief minister's post, invites comparison with a giant like Naveen Patnaik, the transformative effect of whose governance era no one denies. How to get a positive hue in such a juxtaposed frame?

An opening lay in the very promise the BJP made ahead of the poll: "freeing Odisha from the grasp of a babu." The Naveen era was often seen as synonymous with the '*amalatantra*'—or the bureaucracy. Its perceived omnipotence was exemplified by the ascendancy of ex-IAS officer V.K. Pandian to the cabinet-ranked post of 'Chairman 5T (Transformational Initiatives)'. The BJP is keen to establish that, under its reign, public representatives will have the upper hand, not a faceless bishopry of babus. As a cabinet minister says, its regime runs on mutual trust amongst ministers and their secretaries, not by the power skew he alleges defined the erstwhile Biju Janata Dal (BJD) regime.

Accompanying this is a set of two powerful mottos: decentralisation and accessibility, both intended to strike a contrast with the Naveen era. To put flesh and blood on the latter idea, Majhi reaches out to citizens directly at the CM's grievance cell. Frequent visits by Prime Minister Narendra Modi undergird this, exuding a sense of proximity and sync with New Delhi. Modi was at hand in Bhubaneswar on September 17 to launch Subhadra Yojana, under two tranches of which lakhs of poor women have already started getting direct financial assistance. Modi is also set to flag off other key programmes.

Clearly, the BJP is working to a master plan, with the Centre entirely in lockstep with the newly acquired province, and keen to impart the velocity of a 'double engine' regime. All this, of course, is wrapped up in the BJP's patented vocabulary: it paints itself as the flag-bearer of 'Odia *asmita*' (pride). The Subhadra scheme, for one, is named for the Puri Jagannath deity's sister.

The tone was set at the very first Majhi cabinet meeting on June 12, which inked four poll promises: to open the Jagannath temple's four gates; set up a corpus fund of Rs 500 crore for its upkeep; increase the minimum support price for paddy to Rs 3,100 per quintal; and initiate the Subhadra scheme.

A senior minister lets on that several bureaucrats "were unhappy" with the idea of direct cash benefits and registered their reservations at the meeting, essentially on the point that the scheme would leave a dent on the exchequer. "They were probably accustomed with a certain way of doing things, where their word takes precedence. But not with us," he adds.

The bureaucrats were squarely told that Subhadra would roll out under all circumstances, and in case they had specific issues with its architecture, they could propose tweaks and nuances amicably. What followed were multiple brainstorming sessions, which led to a retuning of the initial plan of disbursing the amount over two years. The money—Rs 10,000 per annum—will now be disbursed over five years in two equal biannual instalments to be credited directly to the beneficiary's bank account. The state has also placed a demand with the Centre for partial funding of the scheme.

THE IDEA IS TO PROJECT MAJHI AS AN ACCESSIBLE CM, UNLIKE NAVEEN, WHO COULD NEVER QUITE OVERCOME THE IMAGE OF BEING ALOOF

Purge of the Babucrats

The next step was to winnow out BJD loyalists from the bureaucracy. In a major rejig initiated in July and August, officers such as R. Vineel Krishna and G. Mathi Vathanan, considered close to Naveen and his aide Pandian, were transferred to lesser posts. In their place, Arabinda Padhee, Usha Padhee, Bishnupada Sethi and Shalini Pandit were given more important portfolios. Even before this, the state had seen a spate of resignations from senior and former bureaucrats who held key positions close to the old power centre. Retired IAS officers R. Balakrishnan, Suresh Chandra Mahapatra and Upendra Tripathy, and ex-IRTS officer Manoj Mishra put in their papers. Sujata Karthikeyan, Pandian's wife, went on a six-month leave. A similar reshuffle took place in the police department in September, with over 50 IPS of-